

CHAPTER 1

Prehistoric & Proto-historic Period, Ancient Tribes, and Early Political Powers

1.1 THE STONE AGE IN UTTARAKHAND

The prehistoric period of Uttarakhand is primarily reconstructed through **stone tools** and **rock shelters** discovered across the region’s river valleys. In the Alaknanda Valley, at sites such as Dang and Sweet, archaeologists have recovered hand axes, choppers, and scrapers — evidence confirming early human habitation in the Higher Himalayas. The Kalsi River Valley has yielded Stone Age implements that add to Dehradun’s considerable archaeological wealth, while the Ramganga Valley in Western Kumaon has produced multiple tool types attesting to widespread prehistoric settlement.

The pioneer archaeologists K.P. Nautiyal and Yashodhar Mathpal confirmed Stone Age human habitation in the region through systematic excavations, establishing Uttarakhand’s place within the broader narrative of Indian prehistory.

1.2 MAJOR PREHISTORIC ROCK ART & CAVE SHELTERS

A. Almora District — The Epicentre of Rock Art

Site	Discoverer	Year	Key Features
Lakhu Udiyar (Cave)	Dr. M.P. Joshi	1968	Dalband near Bhadichhina on Suyal River; depicts humans dancing and chasing animals; three colour layers — white (top), brownish-red/pink (middle), black (bottom)
Kasar Devi Temple	—	—	Located on Kashyap Hill; depiction of 14 dancers

Phadka Noli	Dr. Yashodhar Mathpal	1985	Multiple significant rock shelters
Petshala	Dr. Yashodhar Mathpal	1989	Rock shelter complex
Phalsima	—	—	Unique depiction of humans in both yoga and dance postures

The paintings at Lakhu Udiyar are particularly significant. The cave is hawthorn-shaped, and its colour layering — white at the top (representing the latest paintings), brownish-red or pink in the middle (intermediate period), and black at the bottom (the oldest) — mirrors the globally recognized pattern found at the Bhimbetka rock shelters in central India.

B. Chamoli District

The **Gwarkhya Cave**, discovered by Rakesh Bhatt, is located in Dugri village of Tharali tehsil near the Alaknanda River. It contains exactly **41 figures** — 33 humans and 8 animals including sheep, fox, and barasingha. The human figures are depicted in a distinctive trident-like shape, and the overall theme reflects a pastoral culture centred on herding.

At **Kimni Village** in the Pindar Valley, weapons and animals have been painted in light white colour on the rock surfaces.

C. Uttarkashi District

The rock art site at **Hudli** is architecturally distinct from other Uttarakhand sites, having yielded rare **blue-coloured** rock paintings — an unusual pigment choice that sets it apart from the standard colour palette found elsewhere in the region.

1.3 MORTAR-LIKE PITS (CUP-MARKS / OKHLIS)

Prehistoric hemispherical depressions carved on large stones — believed to have astronomical or ritualistic significance — represent another category of archaeological evidence in Uttarakhand.

Site	Discoverer	Year	Details
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Devidhura (Champawat)	Henwood	1856	First archaeological discovery in Uttarakhand
Chandreshwar Temple, Dwarahat (Almora)	Rivet-Carnac	1877	200 cup-marks in 12 parallel rows ; compared to European rock art
Nola Village (Western Ramganga Valley)	Yashodhar Mathpal	—	72 cup-marks documented

Henwood’s 1856 discovery at Devidhura is recognized as the first discovery of archaeological sources in Uttarakhand, making it a landmark moment in the region’s historiography.

1.4 PROTO-HISTORIC TRANSITION: COPPER HOARDS & MEGALITHIC BURIALS

A. Copper Hoard Culture

The Copper Hoard culture represents the **oldest metallurgical tradition** in the Upper Ganga Valley.

Site	District	Year	Findings
Bahadrabad	Haridwar	1953	Copper spears, rings, bangles + Painted Grey Ware (PGW); resembles Godavari valley finds
Bankot	Pithoragarh	1989	8 copper human figures
Naini Patal	Pithoragarh	—	5 copper human figures

The Bahadrabad excavation, conducted by Yagyadatt Sharma, was particularly significant for revealing the coexistence of copper artefacts and Painted Grey Ware pottery — a combination that helps date the site and connect it to broader developments in the Gangetic plains.

B. Megalithic Burials — Malari Village (Chamoli)

The megalithic burial site at Malari Village in Chamoli District was first discovered by Shiv Prasad Dabral in 1956. The burials have been compared to the Gandhara burials of the